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The Painting of a Thousand Memories



What is it that gives an item significance?

Is it how much you paid for it, how rare it is, or how much it is worth? While indeed those things would all make an item worthy of attention, it is the emotional value of the item that gives it true significance. Take for example what would be considered a very rudimentary painting by

anyone else in the world and yet for me it holds more value than a bar of gold. It is not fancy, the techniques were not executed to perfection, the white of the canvas can still be seen and yet to me it is pure beauty. How can something so utterly cheap in appearance hold such value to me? Well, it all lies in who painted it and the memories this painting brings to life.

You see, this painting was created by my father-in-law in the final months of his life, with help from my husband Jason. While it might not seem like it from looking at the pictures, J.C. was only 64 when he lost his fight to stage 4 cancer. And yes, his name really is just the initials J.C. Capps, I can remember the first time J.C. and I met in 2008 I asked my now husband what the initials stood for, and he said “Nothing babe, his name is just J.C.”

In February of 2018, we found out that J.C. had stage 4 esophageal cancer with the possibility of surviving 4-6 months. He could not eat or drink anything and had a feeding tube implanted within a month. He refused to give up hope though and would insist on accompanying Jason on jobs no matter how exhausted he was. As the months slowly crawled forward, we watched in heartbreak as this vital, strong, amazing man deteriorated in front of our eyes. It seemed every day he looked another year older. He was



losing weight so rapidly it felt like he needed a new wardrobe every month. Christmas time came and he was still with us, a true miracle. The doctors kept telling us the end was near, that it could come anytime. Still, he refused to give up. He refused to let the cancer take what little time he had left from him.

Enter January of 2019 and Jason and I were spending one afternoon sitting on the porch swing with J.C. when he said, "I wish I could paint just one more time." My husband and I decided at once if that is what he wanted, we would make it happen. We went and bought everything we could think of that he would need for an oil painting and brought it back. By this point in time J.C. had lost most of his strength and tired very quickly. He could not sit up for long without support, so my husband set everything up in front of J.C.'s couch, where he preferred to rest, and helped his dad to get comfortable. He sat right beside him so J.C. could lean on him if he needed, and that's when the magic happened.



The way J.C.'s eyes lit up was as if we had cast a magic spell. He leaned forward and rubbed his hands together as he examined the canvas. It was as if J.C. had been transported back to art school and he started telling Jason step-by-step how to create an oil painting. The proper way to hold a brush, how to mix the colors to get the one you are searching for, and the techniques required to make it look a certain way. The paint brush fit comfortably in his hand as if it had been just a few minutes and not decades ago since he had last held one. The first touches of color hit the canvas and they were both hooked. Not even an earthquake or a tornado could have torn their attention away from that canvas after that. The stories of family, life, happy times, and sad times were shared in those moments, as a scene slowly started to come to life, a little farm in the middle of nowhere began to form in the background.

The laughter that graced their faces as they recalled a good memory transformed into a bright blue sky. The sadness buried in their past transformed into grey clouds that would float overhead. The little lake they painted became, like the family, the focal point of their piece. The cattails blowing in a nonexistent breeze became the life events they spoke of each on their own, adding a little extra depth to the painting. Until, finally, J.C.'s strength began to wane, his head becoming too heavy to hold up on his own. His hands could no longer hold the brush, so it fell to Jason, who picked it up and followed his father's directions.

Slowly as the days passed, J.C. got weaker and weaker, until talking became even too much for his limited strength. The painting was set to the side, out of the way, unfinished and yet in its blank spaces the story is told. The story of a father and his son, who sat side by side on

chilly winter days to slowly craft a beautiful canvas of memories. As February came to its end so too did J.C. reach the end of his strength. On March 1, 2019, he lost his fight to cancer. The missing depth that a typical art critic may condemn, in truth became the perfecting touches on a painting from the hands of an amazing man and his son. The memories that my father-in-law and husband carefully crafted into this painting will never fade. While this painting can never be claimed to be of any monetary value, it holds more significance to me than any other item that I own.

